5 Free Private Pilot Oral Scenario Cards

Explain the rule. Name the risk. Choose an action.

Practice out loud before reading the answer. Each scenario is a discussion prompt, not a claim about the exact questions your examiner will ask.

HOW TO USE THIS PACK

1. Read the scenario and cover the answer. 2. Give a 60-second rule / risk / action response. 3. Compare with the explanation and follow-up answers. 4. Open the cited regulation and discuss weak areas with your CFI.

FIVE REPS

01 Fuel: a minimum is not a margin

02 Weather: name the airspace first

03 Class D: calling is not communicating

04 Inspections: the ten hours are not a bonus

05 Passengers: daytime landings are not night currency

SOURCES AND STUDY LIMITS

Edition: October 13, 2026. Cited rules checked against eCFR; source-based verification only.
No claim of FAA approval, CFI endorsement, or checkride outcome. Discuss weak areas with your CFI.

Study aid only. Not flight instruction, legal advice, or a POH/AFM replacement. Verify current rules, aircraft documents, charts, and NOTAMs for actual operations. Examples are deliberately simplified and not a complete preflight or eligibility checklist.

Optional deeper practice: aviation workbooks at nickrae.net

OPTIONAL DEEPER PRACTICE

Explore the Private Pilot License Workbook by Nick Rae on Amazon

Browse Nick Rae's full Amazon book catalog

Fuel: a minimum is not a margin

Flight planning / VFR airplane fuel

THE SCENARIO

You are planning a daytime VFR flight in a piston airplane. After accounting for forecast winds, your calculations show fuel to the first intended landing plus 35 minutes at normal cruising speed. Your passenger wants to leave now. Is meeting the minimum enough to make this a good plan?

RULE

Under 14 CFR 91.151(a), you may not begin a VFR airplane flight unless, considering wind and forecast weather, you have fuel to the first point of intended landing and then at least 30 minutes by day or 45 minutes at night, assuming normal cruising speed. In the stated daytime case, 35 minutes exceeds that particular minimum; it is not a complete go/no-go decision.

RISK

A small planning margin can disappear with stronger headwinds, delays, a diversion, or inaccurate usable-fuel and fuel-burn assumptions. Legal minimums are not recommended targets.

ACTION

Verify usable fuel and aircraft-specific performance with the applicable POH/AFM, choose a larger personal reserve, and identify an early fuel-stop or diversion trigger. Add fuel or shorten the leg when the margin is inadequate.

FOLLOW-UP REPS

What changes for a night VFR airplane flight?

The planning reserve becomes at least 45 minutes at normal cruising speed after reaching the first intended landing.

Does a 35-minute daytime reserve guarantee a safe flight?

No. It answers only this fuel-minimum question. Conditions, performance assumptions, diversion options, and personal minimums still matter.

COMMON TRAP

Reciting 30/45 without accounting for winds and forecast weather, or treating the reserve as fuel you intend to use.

Source: 14 CFR 91.151(a) - open current text

Source text checked October 13, 2026. Recheck current rules with your CFI.

More PPL practice: Private Pilot License Workbook on Amazon

Weather: name the airspace first

Weather / basic VFR minimums

THE SCENARIO

You are en route in Class E airspace at 6,500 feet MSL, away from an airport surface area. Flight visibility is 4 statute miles. You estimate that you are only 300 feet below a cloud layer. Can you continue in that position under basic VFR?

RULE

No. In Class E below 10,000 feet MSL, 14 CFR 91.155(a) requires at least 3 statute miles flight visibility and cloud separation of 500 feet below, 1,000 feet above, and 2,000 feet horizontally. Visibility meets the stated minimum; your distance below the cloud does not.

RISK

Cloud clearance provides separation from aircraft that may emerge from clouds. Trying to squeeze beneath a lowering layer also increases terrain and inadvertent-IMC risk.

ACTION

Maintain VFR by changing altitude or route only where terrain, airspace, and weather permit. Turn back, divert, or land before options close. Do not let destination pressure turn a cloud-clearance shortfall into an intentional continuation.

FOLLOW-UP REPS

What if you are in Class E at exactly 10,000 feet MSL?

Use the at-or-above row: 5 statute miles visibility; 1,000 feet below, 1,000 feet above, and 1 statute mile horizontally.

Does this card give all airport surface-area rules?

No. Sections 91.155(c) and (d) add ceiling and visibility restrictions for applicable airport surface areas. Special VFR is a separate subject, not a shortcut assumed here.

COMMON TRAP

Applying the Class E rule to every airspace class, or confusing MSL altitude with height above the ground.

Source: 14 CFR 91.155(a), (c), (d) - open current text

Source text checked October 13, 2026. Recheck current rules with your CFI.

More PPL practice: Private Pilot License Workbook on Amazon

Class D: calling is not communicating

Airspace / arrival communications

THE SCENARIO

You are arriving VFR at an airport while its tower is operating and its Class D airspace is active. You call the correct tower frequency twice but receive no reply. You are approaching the boundary. May you enter just because you tried to call?

RULE

No. For an arrival or through flight, 14 CFR 91.129(c)(1) requires establishing two-way radio communications with the ATC facility providing air traffic services before entering Class D, then maintaining them inside. An unanswered transmission does not establish two-way communications. The regulation includes ATC authorization/deviation provisions; none is given in this scenario.

RISK

Entering without the required communications disrupts traffic coordination and can place you in conflict with arrivals or departures. A late call leaves little room to maneuver safely.

ACTION

Remain outside the airspace while checking the correct frequency, radio selection, volume, and equipment. Choose a safe route that respects surrounding airspace and terrain. Retry or divert rather than crossing the boundary without established communications.

FOLLOW-UP REPS

Once communications are established, are you automatically cleared to land?

No. Section 91.129(i) separately requires an appropriate ATC clearance for landing at an airport with an operating control tower.

What if the tower is closed?

Do not assume the airspace stays Class D or automatically becomes one particular class. Check current chart information, tower hours, Chart Supplement, and NOTAMs; then apply the rules for the airspace actually in effect.

COMMON TRAP

Treating a radio call, airspace entry, and a landing clearance as the same thing.

Source: 14 CFR 91.129(a)-(c), (i) - open current text

Source text checked October 13, 2026. Recheck current rules with your CFI.

More PPL practice: Private Pilot License Workbook on Amazon

For radio practice: Clearance to Confidence on Amazon

Inspections: the ten hours are not a bonus

Airworthiness / annual and 100-hour inspections

THE SCENARIO

A flight school provides a standard-category piston trainer for paid instruction. It has accumulated 101 hours of time in service since its last 100-hour inspection, with no annual or other qualifying inspection since. Its annual is within the preceding 12 calendar months. No alternative inspection program or exception applies. Can the school use it for another local paid lesson?

RULE

No. Under 14 CFR 91.409(b), paid instruction in an aircraft provided by the person giving the instruction requires an annual or 100-hour inspection within the preceding 100 hours in service. The limit may be exceeded by no more than 10 hours only while en route to a place where the inspection can be performed. That is not permission for another lesson.

RISK

A current annual does not excuse exceeding the applicable 100-hour interval. Treating the extension as routine operating time can turn a scheduling problem into a compliance and maintenance problem.

ACTION

Check the maintenance records and time-in-service status with the operator. Arrange the inspection before further covered instruction. Any use of the en-route allowance must actually satisfy the regulation, not disguise a training flight.

FOLLOW-UP REPS

If the airplane uses three hours of the en-route allowance, when is the next 100-hour due?

Those three excess hours count toward the next interval; they do not reset the schedule to 100 additional hours.

Can an ordinary 100-hour inspection replace an annual?

Not unless performed by a person authorized to perform annual inspections and entered as an annual in the required maintenance records, as stated in 91.409(a).

COMMON TRAP

Assuming every rental flight requires a 100-hour inspection. Applicability depends on the operation and the regulation, not simply the word rental.

Source: 14 CFR 91.409(a)-(c) - open current text

Source text checked October 13, 2026. Recheck current rules with your CFI.

More PPL practice: Private Pilot License Workbook on Amazon

Passengers: daytime landings are not night currency

Pilot qualifications / recent passenger experience

THE SCENARIO

You plan a personal Part 91 flight in a single-engine land airplane with a friend. You will carry your friend two hours after sunset. Within the preceding 90 days, your only three takeoffs and landings were made during daylight. You otherwise meet the applicable pilot qualifications. Can you act as PIC with your friend aboard during that period?

RULE

No. Under 14 CFR 61.57(b)(1), carrying persons as PIC from one hour after sunset until one hour before sunrise requires at least three takeoffs and three full-stop landings within the preceding 90 days during that same time window. They must be as sole manipulator of the controls in the same category, class, and type if required. Daytime landings alone do not satisfy this night requirement.

RISK

A pilot may be generally passenger-current yet not meet night passenger-carrying recency. Even meeting the legal minimum does not establish proficiency in night visual cues, approaches, or emergency planning.

ACTION

Do not carry the friend during the restricted period until the requirements are met. Plan an appropriate currency flight or refresher with an authorized instructor, confirm the applicable timing, and assess your actual night proficiency.

FOLLOW-UP REPS

Do night touch-and-go landings count toward this night requirement?

No. Section 61.57(b)(1) requires full-stop landings.

Do these three landings replace all other pilot requirements?

No. Certificates, ratings, applicable medical or BasicMed eligibility, flight-review status, endorsements, and other requirements remain separate checks.

COMMON TRAP

Using sunset alone for this passenger-currency window, or substituting daytime currency for night currency.

Source: 14 CFR 61.57(a), (b)(1) - open current text

Source text checked October 13, 2026. Recheck current rules with your CFI.

More PPL practice: Private Pilot License Workbook on Amazon